Who Can Take What?

A family conversation about sharing the work of your husband's care.

Your daughter has a list of what needs doing. Your son says to call if you need anything. Nobody has said yet which part is theirs.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: hear what each person is willing to take, and write it down. It isn't for deciding your husband's care, and it isn't for handing out jobs to people who haven't offered.

Who should be there

Your husband, if he feels up to it. It's his care, and he may have a view on who does what. Then everyone who is helping or has offered to: your daughter with her list, your son who said to call, the neighbor who keeps asking what she can bring. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests including everyone who is or will be part of the caregiving team, which can mean a family friend or a neighbor. [1]

Someone who lives far away can join by phone. Ask one person to keep the notes. It doesn't have to be you.

How to open

Start with the list and a question, not with a plan you've already made.

It can help to say early on that the work probably won't divide evenly. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that there is probably no fair distribution of work, and that trying to make it even will fail. What you're listening for is what each person is willing to take. [1]

- “There's a lot to do over the next few weeks, and I can't carry all of it. Before we talk about who does what, can I read you the whole list?”
- “Nobody has to commit tonight to something they can't do. I'd like to hear which part each of you would be willing to take.”
- Say what the conversation is for: hearing offers and writing them down. Say what it isn't for: deciding where he goes after the hospital, or going back over who has done what so far.

Questions to ask

Ask your husband

1. Is there any part of this you'd like a particular person to do, or would rather they didn't?

2. Who are you comfortable with seeing this list?

Ask each other

1. Which part of this list would you be willing to take?

2. How much time do you really have over the next few weeks, and on which days?

3. Is there anything on the list you can't do, or would rather not?

4. If you couldn't do your part one week, who could step in?

5. What do you think is missing from the list?

Say for yourself

1. Which of these am I doing now that I'd hand over if one of you offered?

How to write down what was said

Write each offer in the person's own words, with their name. Where nobody has offered, leave the name empty; an empty box is worth knowing about and doesn't have to be filled tonight. Where two people see something differently, write both and don't settle it.

THE TASK	WHO OFFERED	WHAT THEY SAID	WHO COULD STEP IN
Phoning the pharmacy back about its questions	Our son	“I can do that Thursday on my lunch break.”	
Being at the hospital on the day he leaves	Our daughter	“Yes, as long as I know the day by Wednesday.”	His brother, maybe. Nobody has asked him.

What not to decide yet

None of these has to be settled for the work to be shared. Where he goes and the order of the decisions rest on his whole situation and the people who assess him, and medication questions belong to his prescriber and pharmacist. Leave them open.

- Where he goes after the hospital, or what care he has there.
- What order the care decisions go in.
- A job for anyone who isn't in the room or hasn't said yes.
- Who has done enough so far and who hasn't.
- Anything about his medications.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the offers and send them to everyone who was there.
- Who is willing to take each open question to the doctor, the pharmacist, the social worker or your care consultant.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle a disagreement, hand anyone a job, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets the offers onto one page, with the empty boxes left showing.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has talked about who is willing to take which part, and the offers are written down. The care interview adds the rest of the picture: it walks you through your husband's situation area by area, so nothing important is overlooked, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting